



Module 14 Lecture - Psychological Disorders & Therapy and Treatment

Introductory Psychology

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Table of Contents

1	Overview and Introduction	2
1.1	Instructor Learning Objectives	2
1.2	Introduction	2
2	What are Psychological Disorders?	3
2.1	The Study of Disorders	3
2.2	Definition of a Psychological Disorder	4
2.2.1	Atypical and Rarity	4
2.2.2	Cultural and Societal Expectations	4
2.2.3	Harmful Dysfunction	5
2.2.4	The American Psychiatric Association Definition	6
3	Diagnosing and Classifying Psychological Disorders	6
3.1	Introduction	6
3.2	The Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM)	7
3.3	The International Classification of Diseases (ICD)	8
4	Classes of Psychological Disorders	8
4.1	Introduction	8
4.2	Anxiety Disorders	9
4.3	Obsessive-Compulsive and Related Disorders	11
4.4	Post-traumatic Stress Disorders	12
4.5	Mood and Related Disorders	12
4.6	Schizophrenia and Psychotic Disorders	13
5	Conclusion	14
5.1	Recap	14
	Key Terms	14
	Key Terms	17

1 Overview and Introduction

1.1 Instructor Learning Objectives

- Focus on the complexity in discriminating between different classes and types of mental disorders and their unique characteristics

1.2 Introduction

 Discuss: Heads down: raise your hand if you yourself have a mental health condition or know someone affected by a mental health condition

- Many folks think that _____ is a field solely dedicated to mental health, but as we've learned this semester, that isn't fully _____.
 - I would hypothesize that a large reason this is, is that conversations around mental health have exploded within the last two decades.
 - But, we cover this last because we don't want to _____ all the other areas we've talked about!

 Discuss: Come up with an example of a research question, topic, or hypothesis a behaviorist, cognitivist, and bio-psychologist may look at

- However - Today, we'll survey the complex world of psychological disorders, and their unique parts and characteristics are

 Important

If you are in need of mental health treatment, therapy, intervention, or other help, please reach out to a trusted support in helping you find resources. If you

don't know where to start, please let me know, and I can try and help connect you.

2 What are Psychological Disorders?

2.1 The Study of Disorders

- Study of mental health and disorders is just one _____ of psychology!

- A **psychological/mental disorder** according to the American _____ Association:

“a syndrome characterized by clinically significant disturbance in an individual's cognition, emotion regulation, or behavior that reflects a dysfunction in the psychological, biological, or developmental processes underlying mental functioning. Mental disorders are usually associated with significant distress in social, occupational, or other important activities”

- The study of psychological _____ is called **psychopathology**
 - This focuses on _____, treatments, and **etiology**
 - However, there is considerable _____ in the characterization of different conditions (to be covered more in [Definition of a Psychological Disorder](#))
 - I.e., what is _____ versus _____ concerning

? Early in the semester (module 1) we talked about different subareas of psychology, which of the following is most likely to study *sub-clinical* levels of symptoms?

- ☒ A) Clinical psychology
- ☐ B) Counseling psychology
- ☐ C) Biopsychology
- ☐ D) Behaviorism

Explanation:

2.2 Definition of a Psychological Disorder

- As stated before, there is not always a clear _____ about what makes something a “disorder”
 - But we need to discuss the different criteria we might consider in describing something as _____ vs _____

! Important

The purpose of the following sections is to point out the complexity in defining disorders, not necessarily to give one clear answer!

2.2.1 Atypical and Rarity

- At a basic level, we might say that a disorder is something that is **atypical** among most people
 - However, many physical traits, like having red hair are _____, but we wouldn’t describe them as disorders
 - Much like physical traits, _____ traits and behaviors may not necessarily be _____ simply by virtue of being rare
 - Furthermore, some mental disorders may not be as rare as you think!

 Discuss: Describe 1 physical and 1 mental trait that may be rare, but not disordered

2.2.2 Cultural and Societal Expectations

- We may also consider how a person’s behaviors or traits _____

strongly from those around them

- If a person behaves in a socially _____ manner, could this be telling of a disorder?

 Discuss: In our module on social psychology, we covered how there are certain unspoken rules we are bound to in certain contexts, these are called: social [Blank]

- However, we should be mindful that social _____ may very well be dependent on culture, geographical location, and contexts
 - E.g., visual hallucinations may be concerning in one context, but expected in another
- Psychology also has a long, unfortunate history with _____ of those viewed as different
 - E.g., Rosemary Kennedy
 - Thomas Szasz and “The Myth of Mental Illness”

2.2.3 Harmful Dysfunction

- If _____ and _____ unacceptedness aren't sufficient, what else might we consider?
- Perhaps we can understand disorders as defined as having [harmful dysfunction](#) towards _____ or _____
 - E.g., something about our mental _____ causes us to react in a way that is harmful to living; healthy fear of spiders vs. a phobia

 Discuss: Try coming up with another example of a behavior or feeling that may be both unhealthy or healthy, depending on it's severity

2.2.4 The American Psychiatric Association Definition

- The American Psychiatric Association, or APA, provides the following criteria:
 - There are _____ disturbances in thoughts, feelings, and behaviors
 - The disturbances reflect some kind of biological, psychological, or developmental _____.
 - The disturbances lead to significant _____ or disability in one's life
 - The disturbances do not reflect _____ or culturally approved responses to certain events.

! Important

There is no one perfect way to understand and describe what a disorder is - much like with other areas of psychology, we are still learning more.

3 Diagnosing and Classifying Psychological Disorders

3.1 Introduction

- If we can _____ what is “disordered”, then how do we further clarifying what exact _____ a person is affected by?
 - This process of _____ is called **diagnosis**
 - This often involves inspecting the combination of _____ and their _____

! Important

Accurate diagnosis is very important because it greatly helps communication and treatment - but misdiagnosis can be equally harmful!

3.2 The Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM)

- In the United States, the most prominent guide for _____ of mental disorders is the [Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders 5 \(DSM-5\)](#)
- The DSM-5 contains the following information about each diagnosis:
 - _____ of _____, e.g., mood, psychotic, etc.
 - Diagnostic _____, i.e., an overview of what it looks like
 - Diagnostic _____, i.e., specific symptoms necessary for diagnosis
 - _____ rates of the disorder, i.e., how often does a disorder occur in certain groups
 - _____ factors associated with the disorder
 - [Comorbidity](#)

? Men more often are affected by psychotic disorders than women - this would be an example of what type of information from the DSM?

- ☒ A) Prevalence rates
- ☐ B) Diagnostic features
- ☐ C) Diagnostic criteria
- ☐ D) Comorbidity

Explanation:

- The DSM is _____ from a perfect tool, and has been revised many times to reflect updates in psychological _____
 - While widely _____, it's not perfect, and will be subject to many more revisions!

3.3 The International Classification of Diseases (ICD)

- An alternative guide to the DSM, used more _____, is the [International Classification of Diseases 11th edition](#)
 - In my experience, these often are used in the purpose of medical _____ and coding, and *shudders* health insurance
- It is a bit more broad and _____ than the DSM, and also covers physical diseases as well
 - E.g., Y93.D: Activities involved arts and handcrafts. V97.33XD: Sucked into jet engine, subsequent encounter, W61.62XD: Struck by duck, subsequent encounter, W61.12XD - Struck by macaw, subsequent encounter, Z62.89 - Sibling rivalry

 Discuss: As a fun exercise, search up 'funny ICD codes' and consider what holidays might be associated with certain codes

- In the field of clinical psychology, in both research and clinical practice, the DSM is usually preferred for its detail, examples, and _____

4 Classes of Psychological Disorders

4.1 Introduction

 Important

This is probably the densest section of this lecture, try to really 'lock-in' here!

- The DSM-5 provides a nice set of different _____ or classes that disorders fall under. We'll walk through a general description of the classes and some notable highlights in each.
 - Remember, it's important that we _____ between what is clinically concerning, i.e. a disorder, and what is a regular level of

disturbance

4.2 Anxiety Disorders

- The class of **Anxiety disorders** are disorders characterized by excessive and persistent fear and anxiety, and related disturbances in behavior
 - The affect roughly 25 - 30% of individuals at at least one part of the lifespan
 - Within this broader class we can look at the subtypes of:
 - * Specific _____
 - * _____ anxiety disorder
 - * _____ disorder
 - * _____ anxiety disorder
- For **specific phobias**, we are dealing with an _____ levels of fear towards a certain stimuli
 - E.g., Extreme fear towards spiders, snakes
 - Critically, the level of fear must be _____ and paralyzing

 Discuss: What are other specific things folks tend to have heightened fear towards

 Which psychologist tried to impart a phobia in 'Little Albert'?

- ☒ A) Albert Bandura
- ☐ B) B.F. Skinner
- ☐ C) Sigmund Freud
- ☐ D) John Watson

Explanation:

- Now, **Social Anxiety Disorder** is characterized by _____ and

_____ fear or anxiety and _____ of social situations in which the person could potentially be evaluated negatively by others

- To try and minimize anxiety when forced to be in a social situation, one might use **safety behaviors**

- ★ E.g., avoiding _____ contact, rehearsing sentences, being brief, avoiding talking about oneself, avoiding drawing attention to oneself

- The class of **Panic disorders** deal with experiences of recurrent (more than one) and unexpected panic attacks, along with at least one month of _____

concern about additional panic attacks, _____ over the consequences of the attacks, or self-defeating changes in behavior related to the attacks (e.g., avoidance of exercise or unfamiliar situations)

- Isolated or individual panic attacks are _____ sufficient to be consider a panic disorder

- Panic attacks are characterized by sudden and severe onset of physical and psychological symptoms, which reach a _____ within 10 minutes, such as:

- ★ Terror and immense fear
- ★ Feeling dizzy, lightheaded
- ★ Shortness of breath
- ★ Chest pain, palpitations, and or accelerated heart rate
- ★ Nausea or abdominal distress

- E.g., my mom

 Discuss: Try to describe how all 3 of the above disorders are similar and different - go beyond just saying 'anxiety'!

- Finally, **generalized anxiety disorder (GAD)** is a relatively _____ state of excessive, uncontrollable, and pointless worry and _____.

People with generalized anxiety disorder often _____ about routine, everyday things, even though their concerns are unjustified

- Around 5.7% of the population will develop symptoms as some point in their life, with women twice as likely as men.

- Very _____ with mood disorders and other anxiety disorders

 Discuss: Bobby encounters a mime on his visit to Paris, and begins to quickly become extraordinarily anxious, hiding in a cafe and becoming hyper-observant. What type of anxiety disorder is this and why?

4.3 Obsessive-Compulsive and Related Disorders

- **Obsessive-Compulsive and Related Disorders** are those involving _____, intrusive, unpleasant thoughts and repetitive behaviors
- The _____ we'll discuss are:
 - _____ disorder
 - Body _____ Disorder
 - _____ Disorder

Important

Notice I keep making a note of how these disorders are often 'persistent'! Most mental disorders are best described as being somewhat chronic or persistent

- **Obsessive-Compulsive Disorder**
 - A person experiences _____ that are unwanted mental thoughts or images
 - A person experiences _____ that drive them to engage in repetitive or ritualistic mental or physical acts, trying to reduce the obsessions
 - This is not just 'being super organized'!
 - E.g., of compulsions, turning on lights in specific sequences, washing hands constantly
- **Body Dysmorphic Disorder** revolves around _____ with a perceived flaw in physical appearance that is either nonexistent or barely noticeable to other people
 - E.g., Me and Acne
- **Hoarding Disorder** is indicated by the _____ to part with per-

sonal possessions, regardless of how valueless or useless these possessions are. As a result, these individuals accumulate _____ amounts of usually worthless items that clutter their living areas

- E.g., Continuous ordering off of online shipping services and keeping all boxes and items even as they _____ one's living space

 Discuss: Mikey feels a strong sense that he must double check that his garage is closed, so around 20 times a day he will walk outside and open/close his garage to make sure it is fully closed, disrupting his time with his family. This is likely an example of which of the above disorders and why

4.4 Post-traumatic Stress Disorders

- **Posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD)** is a type of disorder in which a person must be _____ to, witness, or experience the details of a traumatic experience (e.g., a first responder), one that involves 'actual or threatened death, serious injury, or sexual violence'. Results in _____, _____ of similar stimuli, _____ negative emotional states, outbursts, and exaggerated startle responses
 - **Flashbacks**
 - E.g., Summer camp kid

Important

Not all traumatic events result in PTSD, and it's important not to conflate a 'bad memory' with the real disorder

4.5 Mood and Related Disorders

- **Mood disorders** are those characterized by severe _____ in mood and _____—most often depression, but also mania and elation

- These fluctuations are more _____ than regular responses to everyday difficulties
- There are two general types:
 - * _____ disorders
 - * _____ and related disorders
- **Depressive disorders** are a group of disorders in which _____ is the main feature. Depression is a vague term that, in everyday language, refers to an intense and persistent _____
 - Often, this is associated with loss of interest and _____, in usual enjoyments
- **Bipolar and related disorders** are a group of disorders in which _____ is the defining feature
 - **Mania** is a state of extreme _____ and agitation. When people experience mania, they may become _____ talkative, behave recklessly, or attempt to take on many tasks simultaneously

? A person is excitedly describing a new invention and plan they have, that they think will be world-changing, but is constantly losing sleep, neglecting hygiene and needs, and isolating from friends. These behaviors are most closely related to:

- ☒ A) Depressive disorders
- ☐ B) Bipolar and related disorders
- ☐ C) PTSD
- ☐ D) Social Anxiety Disorder

Explanation:

4.6 Schizophrenia and Psychotic Disorders

- **Schizophrenia** a psychological disorder that is characterized by major disturbances in thought, _____, emotion, and behavior. Often associated with _____, altered perceptions, and _____
- **Hallucinations** are a perceptual experience that occurs in the absence of

external _____.

- _____ hallucination are the most common in schizophrenia
- E.g., hearing voices
- **Delusions** Beliefs that are contrary to reality and are firmly held even in the face of _____ evidence - absurd
 - E.g., belief that “men-in-black” are spying on you

5 Conclusion

5.1 Recap

- Diagnosis and classification of mental disorders is extremely complex and tricky - real cases are not near as clear-cut as the examples in this lecture! There is also considerable disagreement and need for further research to keep understanding these disorders better.
- There are *many* types of psychological/mental/cognitive disorders, many of which we didn't even get to covering here! More include dissociative disorders (e.g., Dissociative Identity Disorder), neurodevelopmental disorders (e.g., ADHD / ASD), neurodegenerative disorders, (e.g., Alzheimer's disease, Frontotemporal dementia), and more!
- Even within the broader classifications of disorders, there are more specific disorders with specific symptoms sets, clarified and explained in the DSM-5 (but likely subject to change in the future!)

Key Terms

A

Anxiety disorders Disorders characterized by excessive and persistent fear and anxiety, and related disturbances in behavior [9](#)

atypical Unusual or unexpected, rare [4](#)

B

Bipolar and related disorders a group of disorders in which mania is the defining feature. [13](#)

Body Dysmorphic Disorder Preoccupied with a perceived flaw in physical appearance that is either nonexistent or barely noticeable to other people [11](#)

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Comorbidity The tendency for two or more disorders to have overlap or occur together [7](#)

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Delusions Beliefs that are contrary to reality and are firmly held even in the face of contradictory evidence. [14](#)

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Flashbacks intrusive and distressing memories of the event leading to PTSD [12](#)

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generalized anxiety disorder (GAD) A relatively continuous state of excessive, uncontrollable, and pointless worry and apprehension. People with generalized anxiety disorder often worry about routine, everyday things, even though their concerns are unjustified [10](#)

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harmful dysfunction A harming and dangerous malfunction of our cognitive and mental functioning [5](#)

Hoarding Disorder Indicated by the inability to part with personal possessions, regardless of how valueless or useless these possessions are. As a result, these individuals accumulate excessive amounts of usually worthless items that clutter their living areas [11](#)

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